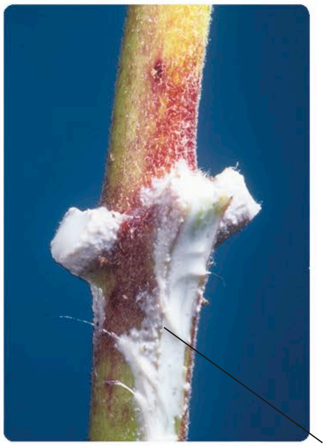
To deter predators, some plants, including the **camel thorn**, produce sharp branches called thorns, while others, such as **gorse**, make sharp leaves known as spines. Prickles are extensions of the stems of plants such as **roses**. Another plant defense strategy is the use of chemicals. Plants, such as **tea**, **common milkweed**, and **blue agave**, produce nasty-tasting or irritating chemicals to put off any animal that takes a bite. The spots on **passion flower** leaves are a clever defense called mimicry—the plant's leaves pretend to be infested by butterfly eggs, which deters real butterflies from looking for a "healthy" leaf.



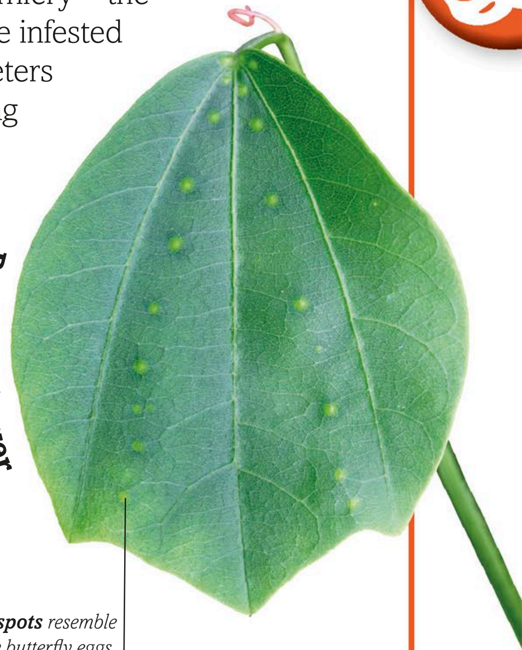
Common milkweed

The gummy white sap *of this flowering plant is toxic to many plant-eating mammals.*

Whistling thorn acacia

Thorns *grow up to 3 in (7 cm) long.*

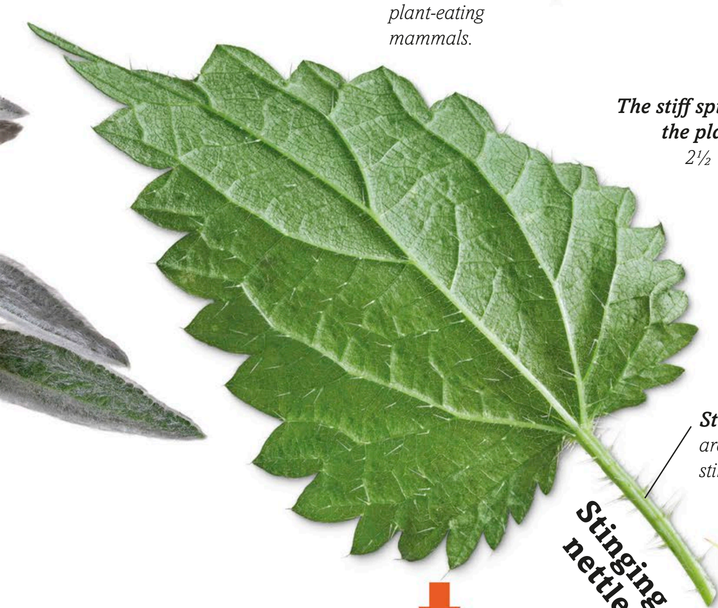
Ants live inside these swollen thorns*, protecting the plant from herbivores.*



Passion flower

Leaf spots *resemble yellow butterfly eggs.*

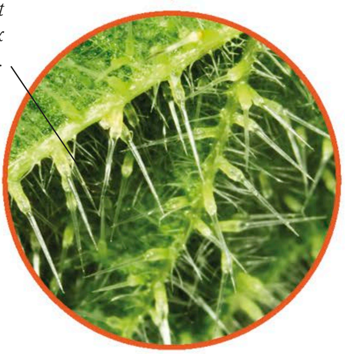
Small birds **nest in spiky gorse** bushes to protect themselves from predators.



Stinging nettle

Stems and leaves *are covered in tiny stinging hairs.*

Needlelike hairs *can inject a painful mix of chemicals.*



Stinging hairs

Gorse

The stiff spines that cover the plant *can be up to 2½ in (6.5 cm) long.*

Buds *contain yellow flowers with a coconut scent.*

Rose

Downward-pointing prickles *grow on the stems of roses to deter predators from climbing up.*